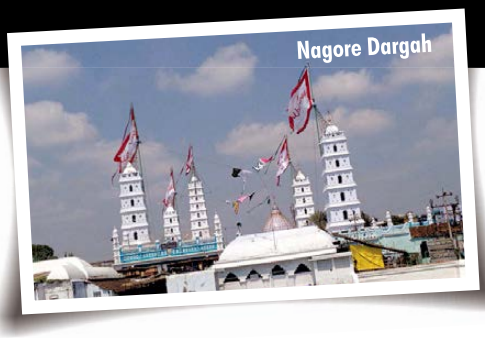


Tiruvannamalai Jothi



Nagore Dargah



Velankanni Church Nagapattinam

other and visit temples. The Meenakshi Temple in Madurai is beautifully decorated, and the city comes alive with processions and cultural events, the highlight being a chariot which runs through the streets of this ancient town.

AADI PERUKKU

Aadi Perukku is a Tamil festival celebrated in the Tamil month of Aadi (July-August). It is a day dedicated to paying homage to water bodies, especially rivers, and is observed as a thanksgiving ceremony for the water's life-sustaining properties. People offer prayers, perform rituals, and take part in festive activities near rivers and water sources during this occasion. It is believed that during the month of Aadi, water levels rise, and rivers flow with abundance, signifying the onset of the monsoon season.

KANDURI FESTIVAL

The 14-day Kanduri Festival takes place at the Nagore Dargah in Nagapattinam District and commemorates the death anniversary of the 16th-century Sufi saint Shahul Hameed. Held in the Islamic month of Jamathul Aagir, the festival is attended by both Hindus and Muslims, showing the syncretic nature of the shrine. A must attend for tourists is the spectacular procession wherein a chariot containing santhanakoodu or sandalwood paste is pulled across the streets of Nagore by pilgrims and devotees. At the end of the ride, the sandalwood paste is received by the descendants of the saint and used to anoint the Rowla Sharif or sanctum of the shrine. The fireworks display during the festival is not to be missed either.



Chithirai Festival

VINAYAKA CHATHURTHI

Also known as Pillayar Chathurthi, this festival celebrates Lord Ganesha, the remover of obstacles. Held in the Tamil month of Avani (August-September), the festival sees devotees worshipping colourful idols of Lord Ganesha in various shapes and sizes which are installed across the State in pandals or marquees. Loudspeakers play devotional hymns and people flock to the streets to dance and express their joy. The festival comes to a dramatic end when the towering idols are bid farewell and immersed in water. To witness the true fervour of the festival, you must head to Vinayaka temples like the Ucchi Pillayar Temple on top of Rock Fort in Tiruchirappalli and the 7th-century Sri Karpaga Vinayakar Temple in Pillayarpatti in Sivaganga district. And you absolutely must try kozhukattai, Lord Ganesha's favourite sweet, during the festival.

ANNAI VELANKANNI CHURCH FESTIVAL

The Velankanni Church Feast is a 10-day festival held at the Velankanni Shrine Basilica of Our Lady of Health at Nagapattinam from August 29 to September 8, which attracts millions of devotees to the shrine. The devout believe that the Mother Mary performed three miracles in this village. The shrine holds a majestic idol of Annai Velankanni. During the festival the Mother Mary is taken in procession around the shrine as devotees follow the deity singing her glory. The Church Museum is a must visit for tourists.

NAVARATHRI

While this nine-night festival is celebrated across India, the festivities have a unique charm in Tami Nadu. Held in the Tamil month of Purattasi (September-October), the festival is dedicated to Goddess Durga. Celebrations in Tamil Nadu are made unique by the elaborate decorations at home, the highlight being the display of golu dolls which are kept on a raised platform. The festival also sees traditional music and dance performances in temples and community centres. The Madurai Meenakshi Amman Temple, Mutharamman Temple in Kulasekharapatnam, and Kanchi Kamakshi Amman Temple are some famous temples frequented during Navarathri for their grand celebrations.

KARTHIGAI DEEPAM

Celebrated in the month of Karthigai (November-December) around the full moon, this festival involves lighting lamps and bonfires, which are believed to ward off evil spirits. The Arunachaleswarar Temple in Tiruvannamalai is particularly famous for its grand celebration during Karthigai Deepam. The last day of the three-day festival sees the lighting of the Mahadeepam at Tiruvannamalai, which is a gigantic bonfire that can be seen for miles around. You can witness the power of faith as devotees throng the temple in thousands on that day. Of course, Karthigai Deepam is celebrated all over Tamil Nadu, with kolams or floral patterns adorning house fronts and clay oil lamps or agal vilaku being lit at night. It's a mesmerising sight.

MAHAMAHAM FESTIVAL

Held every 12 years in the town of Kumbakonam, the Mahamaham Festival is celebrated at the Mahamaham tank during which pilgrims from all over the State gather to take a holy dip in the tank during this auspicious time. The next Mahamaham Festival is in 2028.

Before planning your trip, it would be a good idea to check the specific dates of the festivals as they are based on the Tamil calendar and may vary from year to year. Attending these festivals makes for an enriching holiday because travellers get the opportunity to experience the rich cultural and religious traditions of Tamil Nadu first-hand and at their peak.